Just like Madame Martin, Léa thought. “What was Édouard’s plan?”

“He’s arranged to meet him in the middle of the night. The smuggler will come by *péniche*—a motorized barge. Édouard intended on the donkey hauling the cart loaded with the crates to the river at a place where the embankment isn’t too steep.”

“Then we’ll do the same.”

“The trouble is, the donkey’s frightened of her own shadow. She’s terrible with strangers or sudden noises. Édouard knows how to handle her since he’s raised her from birth. Without him to calm her, she’ll bray all the way there, giving us away.”

It was true that every time Léa had attached the cart to the donkey’s harness and tried to guide her down the hill to the *chai*, the animal wouldn’t budge. Even if she brought a carrot or apple from the orchard, the animal stubbornly stood still. The donkey moved for Édouard only. There had to be another way. “What if we bring the cases through the tunnel?”

“I’ve thought of that.” She took a sip of tea. “But the demijohns aren’t light. And then how will we get them from the tunnel to the river? It’s another three hundred meters.”

“If one of us can be in the tunnel and another one outside with the wheelbarrow at the other end, then we can place two or three crates on the wheelbarrow and bring the demijohns down to the river that way.”

“Possibly. How many trips do you think it would take?”

“Depends on how many crates we can stack on the wheelbarrow—five? If we could get a second wheelbarrow, then we’ll go faster.”

The women sat in silence, running through the logistics in their minds. “Édouard will know if the tunnel is a good idea,” Virginie said, shifting her weight in the chair. “We need to discuss it with him.”

“How?”

“They won’t let me see him when I bring the basket of food.”

“Maybe I can try.” Léa could see Virgine’s eyes lined with exhaustion, strain or both. She’d promised Édouard that she would protect his family. “You will stay with Paulette. Rose and I can transport the bottles.”

Virginie glanced sideways at the door. “I can’t allow—”

“If we’re caught.” She didn’t want to think that way, fearing she’d jinx it, but she was sure Édouard’s instructions were clear and she’d given him her word. “You must say that you aren’t a part of it and know nothing.”